

BRAND BUILDER: BACHCHAN WAS A MEMBER OF THE UTTAR PRADESH DEVELOPMENT COUNCIL

“Despite my proclamations to the contrary, why the deliberate and futile political insinuations? I am promoting tourism for Gujarat. I am not promoting the politics or the governance of Mr Modi, the chief minister, or Mr Modi, the individual.”

AMITABH BACHCHAN
on his blog

“those who brought us into politics abandoned us midway”, there has been silence on the Jalsa-10 Janpath front, with Bachchan’s comment that *“Woh raja hain, ham rank hain”* being the last word. But the association with Modi’s Gujarat as brand ambassador seems to have set off a fire alarm with the Congress spokesmen lashing out at Bachchan, and the CPI (M)-led Left Democratic Front recalling its invitation to be tourism ambassador for Kerala after a rap on the knuckles from Politburo member Sitaram Yechury—a similar admonition was delivered to Chavan by Ahmed Patel for sharing a platform with Bachchan. In the urge to be more loyal than the queen, even Suresh Kalmadi issued a statement that Bachchan would not be the face of the 2010 Commonwealth Games.

Earlier Bachchan would combat such incidents with silence, his chosen state of existence during much of his stardom when he had a stand-off with the film press. But the blog, which he has written now for almost two years, has given him a powerful weapon to hit back, while also perhaps souring his relationship with the media, whom he uses as a pin cushion as often as they use him for target practice. The Congress, by linking their protest to his status as brand ambassador of Gujarat, made it easier for him to earn brownie points as he portrayed himself as the helpless victim of an oppressive power structure, a martyr to the cause of individual freedom. As an

actor, his right to sell anything from soap to a state cannot be questioned. But he is expected to be equally heroic offscreen, aligning with politically correct causes. As he has shown us repeatedly, that is too much to expect from him or from any other actor.

Taking a political stand has a price, as Shah Rukh Khan discovered when he almost reluctantly stood up to the Shiv Sena after they attacked him for saying Pakistani players should have been selected in the IPL. His movie, *My Name is Khan*, was released in Mumbai after much effigy burning and poster tearing when the entire state machinery was put on high alert. Before him, Aamir Khan’s film, *Fanaa*, was unofficially banned in Gujarat theatres because he had supported the Narmada Bachao Andolan. Bachchan was at the receiving end of the Maharashtra Navnirman Sena’s wrath in 2008 when his wife, Samajwadi Party (SP) MP Jaya Bachchan, made the mistake of joking about not being able to speak Marathi. Bachchan has also repeatedly suggested that he has been subjected to Income-Tax questioning because of his closeness to Amar Singh, formerly of the SP and now locked in a perpetual face-off with Sonia Gandhi—he had his own disinvitation saga when he was taken to 10 Janpath by the late H.K.S. Surjeet and then ignored by the host.

Bachchan, once one of Rajiv Gandhi’s closest friends, invented the new business-entertainment-politics alliance in Bollywood. At the height of his second coming, he was very much part of the awesome foursome that included Anil Ambani, Amar Singh and



“He is a great artiste who has chosen to celebrate the glorious heritage of Gujarat even while facing a lot of criticism. It is an inspiring matter.”

NARENDRA MODI



“Mr Bachchan, what are your views on the Gujarat Government’s complicity during the riots? You must explain your position.”

MANISH TIWARI